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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' meeting with President of Sri Lanka Ranil Wickremesinghe on the sidelines of the 19th Summit of the Non-Aligned Movement that concluded on Saturday in Kampala of Uganda.

PM discusses regional collaboration with Sri Lankan President

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has met President of Sri Lanka, Ranil Wickremesinghe on the sidelines of the 19th Summit of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) that concluded on Saturday in Kampala of Uganda.

The two leaders held a bilateral delegation-level discussion on the occasion.

In the meeting, Prime Minister Prachanda said that since Nepal and Sri Lanka stand together in matters of non-aligned foreign policy, it is necessary for both countries to forge collaboration in matters of regional issues and interests.

He also emphasized on the need to make the South Asian Regional Cooperation Organisation (SAARC) active and dynamic, and said that a common role should be played for that. PM Prachanda stressed that regional cooperation and issues of common interest should be addressed by making SAARC dynamic.

The two delegations also talked about conducting direct flight from Sri Lanka to Gautam Buddha International Airport.

Sri Lankan President Dr. Wickremesinghe said that Sri Lanka will continue to support the process to revive the SAARC and stressed on the need for cooperation between Nepal and Sri Lanka in regional interests and common economic activities.

The Nepali delegation included Foreign Minister NP Saud, Prime Minister's Foreign Affairs Adviser Dr. Rupak Sapkota, Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal and other officials of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

PM Prachanda had left for Kampala on Thursday, January 18. Addressing the summit with the theme 'Deepening global cooperation for shared global affluence' on Friday, PM Prachanda suggested for a reform in the global financial architecture in order to enable countries in special situation to secure finance in achieving their development visions.

He demanded that the developed nations should fulfill their financing commitment without delay.

PM Prachanda also said that the NAM must focus on economic development and prosperity of its members the timely achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). He called for south-south cooperation capitalizing on the technological and socio-economic development achieved by the NAM members, and removing institutional capacity constraints faced by developed and least developed countries.

Meanwhile, speaking to media after the summit in Kampala, PM Prachanda said that while the movement was the result of the Cold War, its relevancy has been increased in the current situation where the world has been facing multiple war and polarisation.

"Speaking at the summit, various leaders have said that the relevancy and importance of NAM has increased," he said.

He also said that during a brief encounter with Indian External Affairs Minister, Dr. S. Jaishankar, he said that Nepal and India should expedite the process to implement Pancheshwor Project in order to achieve shared prosperity.

Nepal is a founding member of NAM and has been attending the NAM summit actively since its establishment in 1961. PM Prachanda will return home on Sunday.

Experts suggest building quake-resilient housing settlement using local materials and technology

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

A number of integrated settlements were established as a result of post-disaster recovery actions of the government in some districts after the nation was struck by 2015 Gorkha Earthquake.

Integrated settlement established at Gumsipakha of Gorkha was one of them. The initiative was to relocate Laprak villagers from there to Gumsipakha. But today, hardly 25 families live in that settlement. The reason is the houses built there were small, narrow, and built with little consideration for the climate of the locality or of the lifestyle of residents (especially of Gurung community). Importantly, the area lacks proper source of water although initiative was taken to bring water there, but it went in vein.

TRN SPECIAL

Also, the government initiated a plan to relocate locals residing in Yasikai village of Rapti Municipality in Chitwan, to Kalitar area, which is six km west to the original place after they also got affected by the Gorkha quake. The National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), now scrapped, provided land and Rs. 6.5 million to construct new houses, but no one went there to reside.

Some 56 families of Kapurgaun in Dhading district were also relocated to Bhuwalepani and Ale areas following the earthquake. The NRA spent Rs 4.5 million to build the new settlement, but after living there for a short time, people started moving back to their original place (Kapurgaun).

The reason was the same: the new settlement had houses but no arrangement for farming and animals or any employment opportunities.

Hence, the reconstruction experts and the government officials have themselves suggested the government that the reconstruction of permanent housing and settlement damaged by different earthquakes should be done considering that area's geography, culture, social, and economic aspects.

"The houses all look the same, but they do not reflect the integrated townscape of traditional Gurung village," he said.

"The houses and the location that the government made were just not suited for farming families, there is no space for storing their harvest, or to build sheds for pet animals or even for the children to play," said Dr. Surya Raj Acharya, an expert on infrastructure policy, planning and management.



PHOTO: NDRRMA

A quake-resilient model hospital built by the government in Achham district.

Experts said that today in Gumsipakha, only 50 of the 573 new uniformly built houses are occupied.

"Laprak has now become a reference of how even well-intentioned disaster response can be inappropriate, thus we must look into all factors ," Anil Pokhrel, Chief Executive Officer for the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), said while talking to The Rising Nepal, on Friday.

Dr. Acharya blamed the government for arbitrarily approving designs without understanding the local needs and social history. The settlements thus built in Gorkha, Chitwan and Dhading district are doomed to turn into ghost towns when the locals start leaving it gradually, complaint Dr. Achayra.

Before planning a new integrated settlement, he said, it would be necessary to study whether it was suitable for the family for whom the house was to be built, how far the farms are from the settlement, and the livelihood of the people.

The former CEO of the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), Sushil Gyawali said that the houses were made smaller because there was not enough money, and admitted that integrating the livelihood aspects with the new designs was never implemented.

Gyawali said, "If the plan was implemented properly, there would not have been complaints like this."

Reconstruction may delay

CEO Pokhrel said that the reconstruction drive to be implemented by the government through the NDRRMA might take time to kick off. Housing quake survivors in their reconstructed houses before upcoming monsoon may not be possible, he said.

As the construction of makeshift housing is still going on there in Jajarkot and Rukum West and other adjoining districts, including Salyan, reconstruction of permanent infrastructure may be delayed, CEO Pokhrel said.

Beneficiaries close to 80,000

With the addition of the number of beneficiaries affected by the Jajarkot earthquake, it has reached 79,599 as of Thursday (January 18), according to the NDRRMA, on Friday.

More than 12,000 beneficiaries were added last time. According to the NDRRMA, the number of beneficiaries has reached 79,599 after the local levels undertook last update and sent the data of the beneficiaries who were missed to be counted earlier.

Prakash Chandra Adhikari, head of private housing and reconstruction branch under the Authority, said

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Govt charting out good governance roadmap: Acting PM Khadka

RSS
Narayangadh Jan 20:



Acting Prime Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka said the government was in preparation to chart out national action plan with governance road map.

Inaugurating the three-day trainers' training hosted by Nepali Congress Training Academy Nawalparasi (Bardaghat Susta East) at Gaidnakot today, he said the government would announce a plan of action with governance roadmap within a month.

"The service recipients would free from the hassles in accessing public services in two or three months following the rollout of this campaign. The government in turn would gain public trust", he added.

The acting PM claimed that service recipients have felt respite with gradually improving service delivery from government offices. The government he said has stepped up its efforts to resolve the problem of landless and haphazard settlement, he added.

Khadka also shared that the government was working to reduce revenue in a way to minimize economic burden among the people.

Also speaking on the occasion, NC central member Govinda Bhattarai said NC had a lead role in formulating policies in the country. NC had worked with remarkable plan in different time but due to lack of the management of performance data other parties are taking the credit.

As many as 45 NC frontline cadres from all local Palikas of Nawalparasi (Bardaghat Susta East) are taking part in the training, informed Balkrishna Ghimire, NC Nawalpur Training Academy Chief.

Locals worry over fading glacial lake

RSS
Manang, Jan. 20

Kalu Ghale, born and grown up at Bhraka village of Ngisyang rural municipality-5 in the upper Manang, turns nostalgic seeing weird changes in nature.

The glacier that arrives at his doorstep and the splendid nature are the matters of past. "The Gangpurna Lake located at the height of 3,820 meters has gradually turned into an arid land," he said expressing utmost despair.

If the lake had persisted, it could help attract tourists, but in vein. Ghale reminds, "Even the Swiss geologist Toni Hagen had photographed the Gangapura Lake in 1957 and used to bear for publicity. Since then, the lake has been made a base of further study on geological structure and climate change impacts here."

Nearly nine-km long glacier is receding every year. It has been studied by foreign research centre as well.

According to Shalik Ram Sigdel, one among the research team, the climate change, unusual avalanche and rainfall were causing existential threat to the lake.

Similarly, a Visit-Manang campaigner Phurba Tamang said although new lakes like Tilicho and Gangapurna were being explored in Manang of late, the conservation of Gangapurna Lake must be kept in priority. The glacial lake, which is being studied for half century, should not be tuned out.

A team of local tourism campaigners including Phurba had found a new lake located 25 meters away from Chame. It was named Kajinsara Lake. Although the lake was publicized as the one located even above the Tilicho Lake, a scientific verification is awaited.

In view of the researchers' warning over the extinction of the lake and changes in nature, the rural municipality has allocated Rs 30 million to restore pristine lake. Chairman of Ward-6 of Ngisyang rural municipality, Sonam Gurung, shared that even a notice was issued for it. The silted up lake is being dredged now, he added.

Construction materials piled-up on roadside cause accidents

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Jan. 20

Locals in Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City are found violating the rules of the sub-metropolis causing risks of accidents and traffic management.

The sub-metropolis prohibits its denizens from storing construction materials like gravel, bricks, iron rods, and sand on street corners and public spaces for a long period. If needed the locals are required to get permission from the ward office of the sub-metropolitan office.

Meanwhile, the piling up of construction materials is seen at many places in the city for days and the sub-metropolis is seen failing to implement the rule.

Mubarak Siddiki, a local of Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City-11, said



that the sub-metropolis failed to remove construction materials though it had obstructed roads increasing the risks of vehicle accidents.

Ram Suresh Yadav, a local of Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City-13, questioned why the sub-metropolis did not take any action against such activities. It even created hindrances for pedestrians, he added.

Locals complained that the city police had ignored them even when people were found piling up construction materials in the middle of roads. This also created difficulty in traffic management. Though they made a complaint to the concerned authorities, no action had been taken.

The locals of Sadarline, Triveni Section, Ranitalau Road, Tribhuvan Chowk, and Eidgha Road are found storing construction materials on the roads while constructing their houses.

Meanwhile, Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City Deputy Mayor Kamaruddin Rai said that they will not allow anyone to store construction materials in public spaces and roads.

He said city police and employees were constantly monitoring the activities. He also urged its denizens to inform the sub-metropolitan office if anyone is found compiling construction materials on roads.

Economy on track to normalcy: Minister Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that Nepal's economy is gradually returning to normalcy. Addressing the Govinda Biyogi Journalism Award and senior journalist honouring ceremony established by the Govinda Biyogi Memorial Trust in Nuwakot, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that there has been an improvement in real estate business, the NEPSE index has risen and other indicators of the economy have also improved.

"The economy is slowly returning to normal. The land business has been active, the NEPSE index has risen. After many years, a high number of tourists have entered the country. A lot of capital from outside has flowed into the system," he said.

According to a press statement from his secretariat, Minister Mahat said that the confidence of the businessmen and investors and the general public has also been boosted towards the country's economy with the improvement of economic indicators. He said, "Economic growth will increase this year compared to last year. New areas of investment should be identified."

Stating that the confusion in the economy is coming to an end, he said that the media should actively disseminate positive comments which boost the confidence among the people.

Minister Dr. Mahat said, "When I took over the responsibility of the Ministry of Finance, there were many problems. There were many problems in the budget management as well. The challenge was to bring it to the right track. It was difficult to clear that situation in one stroke. But now, work is being carried out gradually to address the problems seen in the economy."

Stating that there were challenges in the economy as a whole due to external and internal reasons, he said that there was a huge debt flow before and during the COVID-19 pandemic, when there was no place to spend.

"Since there was no place to invest during COVID, a huge amount had been invested in share market and real estate," he said, "so tight monetary policy introduced to stop this. Due to non-return of investment, liability increased and the interest rate has also increased. The borrowers who took the loan at that time are in trouble. This problem has now become the main topic of discussion."

The Finance Minister made it clear that journalism is not in problem due to the country's economic situation. He said, the main reason why journalism is in trouble is social media.

He said, "The development of information technology has put the traditional media at risk. There is a smart phone in hand, anyone can post anything with that. Some false things are also being shared. The same thing starts to seem true to people. Common people stopped reading serious things. People stopped going deep, and started enjoying TikTok. The people who reached the depth and understood the truth and made opinions left the arena. This is extremely dangerous."

He said that people should not depend only on social media, mainstream media should also be brought forward. He said that the state could not support any organisation due to the difficult economic situation of the country. He said that once the situation eases, the importance of organisations will be understood and support will be provided again.



PHOTO: TRN
Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat addressing Govinda Biyogi Journalism Award ceremony on Saturday.

QUAKE SURVIVORS RECEIVE FIRST INSTALLMENT

RSS
Jajarkot, Jan. 20

A total of 27,091 people have received the first installment of grant support for temporary housing in Jajarkot. Out of 42,524 survivors, 27,091 victims have received the first installment, according to a statement issued by the District Administration Office.

Altogether 4,642 of the 6,634 suvivors of Bheri Municipality, 7,150 of 8907 of Nalgad Municipality, 2,188 out of 8,205 in Chedagad have received the grant assistance, said Administrative Officer of the District Administration Office, Harishchandra Sharma.

In Barekot, out of 5,586, 4,687 and among 5,287 families of Kushe rural municipality, 4,154 families have received the first installment of temporary housing grant assistance. Similarly, the first installment has been provided to 1,113 families out of 5,406 in Junichande Rural Municipality. The first installment has been provided to 3,147 families out of 3,309 survivor families in Shivalaya Rural Municipality.

Currently, only 10,159 families are living in temporary structures, with 32,365 families still living under tents.

Rana makes millions out of orange cultivation



PHOTO: TRN
Bhim Bahadur Rana's orange in market.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Jan. 20

Bhim Bahadur Rana, a resident of Devghat Rural Municipality-1, Tumi, in Tanahun, serves as an inspiring example that skilful agricultural practices can yield substantial financial returns. As the chairman of the Devghat Area Development Committee and a dedicated farmer, Rana has successfully generated an annual income of approximately 5 million rupees by specializing in orange cultivation. This year alone, Rana's revenue reached an impressive 5.2 million, surpassing the 4.9 million earned in the previous year.

Attributing the increase in income to the enhanced growth of seeds this year, Rana disclosed that he achieved this financial success by directly supplying oranges to the Kalimati Fruit Market in Kathmandu, circumnavigating intermediary channels.

The prosperous results of his orange farming venture have allowed farmer Rana to make significant investments in his lifestyle. Notably, he has constructed a new house, purchased two vehicles, and acquired additional properties in Damauli and Narayangadh. Rana proudly shared that his 1,200 orange plants, cultivated across a 113-ropani plantation area, contribute to an annual income that amounts to approximately 50 per cent of his overall earnings.

Reflecting on his journey, Rana emphasized the positive impact of consistent effort and quality produce. Over the years, he has not only achieved financial success but has also inspired his neighbours to venture into orange farming. With decades of experience in cultivating oranges in all his land, Rana expressed his belief that hard work can turn the soil into a source of prosperity, akin to growing gold. Encouraging others, he remarked, "There's no shame in hard work, and deserting homeland for foreign opportunities is unnecessary."

VAIDYA ENERGY LAUNCHES NEW ATHER SHOWROOM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Vaidya Energy has launched its second Experience Centre (showroom) of Ather Scooter in Jhamsikhel of Lalitpur district.

"Following the successful launch of Service Centre at Tinkune just a week ago, this latest addition marks a significant milestone in our commitment to revolutionizing urban commuting with sustainable solutions," said the company.

At the new showroom in Jhamsikhel customers can explore the entire range of Ather Electric Scooters and experience cutting-edge technology firsthand. The company also said that it will launch another Centre in Pokhara by February, followed by more in Chitwan, Butwal, and Itahari within next four months.

"In tandem with our Experience Centre openings, Ather Energy Nepal is committed to bolstering the charging infrastructure across Nepal," said the company.

The company plans to install a total of 10 chargers in Kathmandu ensuring convenient access to charging facilities. Additionally, each of the upcoming cities—Pokhara, Chitwan, Butwal, and Itahari — will receive four chargers, contributing to a robust network that empowers Ather Electric Scooter users to explore every corner of the country with confidence, sustainable and accessible infrastructure.

According to the company, Ather scooters are designed for a new generation of riders who demand style, performance, and sustainability.

Vaidya Energy has successfully launched its leading model, the 450X with two battery choices: 2.9 kWh and 3.7 kWh, catering to a broader spectrum of customer preferences.

Developing nations need to focus on climate change: Chaudhary



PHOTO: TRN
Nirvana Chaudhary, the Managing Director of Chaudhary Group participating in World Economic Forum's program representing Nepali private sector.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Nirvana Chaudhary, Managing Director of Chaudhary Group, has said that since less developed countries including Nepal are suffering from the effects of climate change, the first world should pay serious attention to this.

Speaking at the World Economic Forum in Davos of Switzerland representing the Nepali private sector on Friday, he emphasized that the advanced countries should join hands with others and move forward to minimise the negative impacts of climate change which has become a serious challenge.

Chaudhary was the only participant from the Nepali private sector at the Forum that deliberated upon the important global agenda.

Speaking at the 'Alpine Economies at 2C' session, Chaudhary said that the world should consider climate change as the main challenge of the present time as the global warming is affecting the Himalayan and mountainous countries like Nepal at a rapid pace.

"Nepal has been experiencing the harmful effects of climate change. Our glaciers are beginning to recede. We have started experiencing the effects of extremely cold weather in the Himalayan region and extremely hot weather in the Tarai (southern plain) region," he said while stating that in the future, there will be a lack of water for agriculture and hydropower, as well as for household supply.

He said that to deal with the climate change, it is necessary to create a climate problem solution platform that includes all aspects focused on mountain communities. In addition, it is necessary to bring sustainable projects with a focus on the Himalayan community together with corporate and charitable organizations, he said.

About three decades ago, Chaudhary's father, Binod Chaudhary, Chairman of Chaudhary Group and Member of Parliament, had participated in the World Economic Forum. Binod was given the title of 'Global Leader for Tomorrow'. In 2021, the World Economic Forum nominated Nirvana as a 'Young Global Leader (YGL)'.

Simkot Airport set to extend runway

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan. 20

The Simkot branch of the Civil Aviation Authority has initiated land acquisition process for the expansion of Simkot Airport. The commencement of this crucial phase follows the publication of information, including details about the area on the west side of the airport proposed for acquisition.

Mahendra Bahadur Singh, Airport Chief, confirmed that the preliminary steps for acquiring 60,000 acres of land on the west side have been officially declared. Singh explained that a preliminary notice has been issued to inform the landowners about the impending acquisition, and soon the names of the landowners and the specific areas under consideration will be published in a national newspaper.

The proposed expansion is expected to add 150 metres to the current airport's land, thereby extending the length from 750 to 850 metres. This enhancement is anticipated to accommodate forty-five-seater aircraft, a notable improvement from the current capacity that limits landings to smaller fourteen- to eighteen-seater planes.

The expansion aims to alleviate the pressure on air passengers, particularly during peak tourist seasons, when Simkot Airport experiences air traffic congestion.



PHOTO: TRN
Simkot airport as seen in the picture.

Ski lift in Kalinchowk



PHOTO: TRN

Technicians at first model 200 metres long ski lift which is about to operate in of Dolakha district.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dolakha, Jan. 20

The first model 200 metres long ski lift is about to operate in Kalinchowk in Kuri of Dolakha district.

Uttam Bhattarai, director of the Nepal Mountaineering Training Institute (NMTI) under the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA), informed that this ski lift is one of the infrastructures for the adventure centre to be built in Kuri.

The ski lift, built with the financial support of Switzerland's Katrina Experience, has been installed and tested. It is being going to be launched next week.

The lift's primary work is to bring those who came down from the ski game up again. Those who come down to the game do not have to go up on foot. It is expected to become a means of promoting tourism here.

Its internal support is provided by Ski and Snow Board Foundation and external support is provided by NNMDA. There are 1,310 mountains of over 6,000 metres in Nepal where skiing is possible. If only one of these can be developed into a ski mountain, tourist flow could be increased significantly.

As this is a model initiative, it is expected that the local levels of the districts where there is snowfall would learn from it.

The NMTI has prepared the master plan for the construction of an adventure center at a cost of about Rs. 500,000, and the ski lift has been prepared as a component of it, said Bhattarai.

According to the Pass Consultant, the company that prepared the master plan of the project, it will cost about Rs. 280 million including VAT for its construction. The centre would be expanded to an area of 113,000 square meters.

Alternatives have also been sought to make this viable year-long tourism activity. It receives snowfall for only two months in a year.

The centre will feature a water tank with a capacity of 100,000 litres, a spiritual meditation center, artificial snow production technology, and ice skating. The master plan also mentions that structures such as artificial wall climbing, quad bikes (seven meters long and 5.5 meters wide) and 700 meters T-bar route will be built.

There will be easy and moderate ski routes for beginners and complex ski routes for experts.

Being close to the headquarters of Charikot and Kathmandu and having the temple of Kalinchok Bhagwati are its strengths, while lack of water resources, lack of quality roads, and lack of government policies despite the abundant potential of the tourist area are the weaknesses.

Good medical care for children is a must: Speaker Bista



PHOTO: TRN

Amar Bista, Speaker of the Koshi Provincial Assembly observing the Kathmandu Institute of Child Health (KIOC) within Damak Children's Hospital led by Bhagwan Koirala.

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHREL
Damak, Jan. 20

Amar Bista, Speaker of the Koshi Provincial Assembly, emphasised the importance of good medical care for children during his visit to the Kathmandu Institute of Child Health (KIOC) within Damak Children's Hospital led by Bhagwan Koirala on Thursday evening.

Highlighting the ongoing free treatment programme initiated by the Koshi Province government, Speaker Bista advocated for the inclusion of such specialized children's hospitals in the initiative. The newly operational Damak Children's Hospital, with a capacity of 50 beds, has become a reality through collaborative efforts from the state government, federal government, local government, and various partners.

Speaker Bista, acknowledging the Koshi state government's commitment to providing free health treatment for children, expressed the need to discuss strategies to further enhance connectivity and accessibility. He pledged continuous support for the hospital's endeavors.

Under the Child Health Programme, the state government had previously announced free medical treatment for children up to 10 years old, extending to specialized medical services. Dr. Nabin Dhakal, coordinator of the Children's Hospital, reported that all services, including OPD, Emergency, a well-equipped laboratory, and NICU, are fully operational. Additionally, the construction of the operating room for surgeries has been completed.

Dr. Dhakal noted the overwhelming patient response, with all 50 beds currently occupied despite the hospital's recent opening. He credited the Koshi state government for substantial support in building and maintaining the hospital.

The Nepal Red Cross Society Damak sub-branch contributed the land and building to the hospital, and the Kathmandu Institute of Child Health (KIOC) played a pivotal role in making the children's hospital fully functional by constructing new facilities and maintaining existing structures.

During the same event, Speaker Bista inaugurated the Damak JCJS channel, connecting the hospital premises for the benefit of the sick and disabled. Damak Jaycees President Mukesh Agarwal led the inauguration ceremony.

Funeral rites of Hari Prasad Aryal performed

BY RADHA KRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Jan. 20

The funeral rites of the late Hari Prasad Aryal, who was killed while serving in the Russian Army have been done amid a poignant ceremony involving a grass (Kush) dummy. Aryal was a 23-year-old resident of Waling Municipality-14 Mankhu.

Upon learning about Aryal's demise, his family eagerly awaited the arrival of his body to perform the final rites. After nearly two months passed with no indication of receiving the body.

Bodhraj Kunwar (Raju), Ward Chairman of Waling Municipality-14 informed that, out of desperation, the family created a statue of grass (Kush) on the shores of Kaligand in Ramdi and conducted the funeral rituals of Aryal.

According to Ward Chairman Kunwar, the family initially held onto the expectation that the body would be repatriated, but in the absence of any positive developments, they decided to initiate the last rites and observe the necessary rituals, for the peace of the departed soul.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs communicated the unfortunate incident to the family through the ward office on December 28, revealing that the demise occurred on December 3.

Upon learning about Aryal's demise, his family eagerly awaited the arrival of his body to perform the final rites. After nearly two months passed with no indication of receiving the body.

Aryal, who had initially served in the Nepali army, resigned from his position after nearly three years and subsequently traveled to Russia via Dubai.

Unfortunately, Aryal, who arrived in Russia from Dubai on October 3, met his end in the line of duty.

The family adhered to Hindu customs in honouring the memory of Hari Prasad Aryal.

This solemn event echoes a similar occurrence when the body of Pitam Karki from Putlibazar Municipality-5 in Syangja was not recovered, prompting the family to craft a grass (Kush) effigy and perform the final rites.

Tragically, both individuals met their end in the line of duty.

Number of water birds increases in Ghodaghodi wetlands

BY CHANDANI ACHARYA
Ghodaghodi, Jan. 20



PHOTO: TRN

Birds swimming at Ghodaghodi wetlands.

According to statistics from a water bird count conducted by a group of ornithologists in the Ghodaghodi area, the bird population has increased this year compared to last year.

The winter water bird count for this year is concluded on Tuesday, and the Ghodaghodi Ramsar (wetland) area in Kailali, which stands as the first bird sanctuary saw a surge in the number of water birds.

An ornithologist and field manager of Bird Conservation Nepal Hirulal Dangaura reported that this year, 1,231 waterbirds were counted in and around Ghodaghodi. In contrast, only 855 water birds were counted last year, indicating a significant increase in the number of birds this year.

There are 70 species of waterbirds among the birds found in the Ghodaghodi wetland. Ornithologists have identified the change in the number of birds as the main reason for the alteration in the ecological system in the area.

In last year's count, 17 species of water birds were found, but this year, the count has increased to 36 species. Out of these 36 species, 13, including the Lesser Whistling-duck, Chinese Spot-billed Duck, Common Moorhen, and Bronze-winged Jacana, belong to indigenous species.

According to the ornithologists, in 2003, it was discovered that there were 20,000 waterbirds in the Ghodaghodi area, leading to its listing in Ramsar in that year. However, over two decades, the bird population in Ghodaghodi decreased to 1,231.

Overall, it has been observed that the number of waterbirds has decreased in the Ghodaghodi wetlands over two decades. The submitted government report, in the year the Ghodaghodi area was listed in Ramsar, indicated the presence of 20,000 water birds in this area.

The ornithologist highlighted that among the birds exclusive to Nepal, the Cotton Pygmy-goose, Common Moorhen, White-breasted Waterhen, and Chinese Spot-billed Duck breed in the wetland. The counting of water birds began in 1987 in the wetland area. According to the annual census, the report indicates that the situation of waterfowl is currently facing a crisis.

According to the ornithologist participating in the annual census, the African Comb Duck has not been sighted since 2018. Ornithologist Dangoura reported that among the visitors, several duck species including Common Pochard, Common Teal, Red-crested Pochard, Gadwall, and Mallard were absent compared to the previous year.

Additionally, he said that the Northern Pintail has not been observed in the Ghodaghodi wetland since 2014. The number of Common Coot, which typically arrives as a guest bird, has decreased compared to the previous year.

As soon as snowfall commences in the North Pole, birds in that region initiate their migration. Winter visitors from China, Russia, and Mongolia, as well as from Europe, Korea, and the Tibetan region, migrate to Nepal. Similarly, birds from Turkmenistan, Kazakhstan, and Siberia in Central Asia also travel here in search of food.

More than 150 species of birds are recorded to migrate to Nepal during the winter. They come to escape the harsh winter conditions that pose challenges to their diet and food sources. Ornithologist Dangaura informed that these birds typically begin arriving in the last week of September and return in March.

Bird Conservation Nepal has reported records of 380 bird species in Ghodaghodi, encompassing water birds, forest birds, grassland birds, as well as those residing in farmlands and open spaces. According to Dangoura, 17 conservationists took part in the water bird count in Kailali, led by Bird Conservation Nepal, Division Forest Office Pahalmanpur, and Bird Conservation Network.

Mai Municipality provides door-to-door healthcare service

BY KOKILA DHAKAL
Ilam, Jan. 20

The Mai Municipality-7 Ward Office in Ilam has launched an initiative to extend door-to-door health services to residents within the ward. Buddhi Prasad Khanal, Ward Chairman, announced that a health check-up service has been started for patients facing difficulties in reaching hospitals due to various reasons such as illness, age, or disability. The dedicated team of health workers is now conducting door-to-door visits, providing examinations, and dispensing necessary medications.

Khanal emphasized the importance of addressing the needs of those who due to their health conditions, are unable to visit hospitals. "Our health workers are reaching out to individuals who struggle to access medical care, to ensure that they receive necessary attention at their doorsteps," said Khanal.

"We have found that some sick and disabled individuals cannot even make it to health institutions to obtain basic medications like Paracetamol. We have taken proactive measures to bring health services directly to their homes," he added.

Upon reaching the homes of residents, the health workers conduct thorough examinations, provide essential treatments, and offer guidance on whether further medical attention is required at a hospital.

Khanal said that this initiative is not limited to the elderly and disabled; rather, it extends to all residents within the ward who require medical assistance. "Our commitment to delivering healthcare services at home will continue," assured Khanal.

"In the past, the ward has successfully provided health insurance to citizens aged 60 and above. We are actively working to enhance the accessibility of healthcare services for all residents in the ward," he said.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notification regarding Financial Bid Opening

(Date of Publication : 21 January 2024)

With reference to the Financial Bid Opening Notice Published on 30 July 2023 & 8 August 2023 and pursuant to clause 27.7 of instructions to bidders of bidding document, this is to notify that the following bidder has been considered substantially responsive in technical bid evaluation by Review Committee and decided by the Chief of Public Entity. The concerned bidder is informed to attend the financial bid opening at Nepal Electricity Authority, Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate on the schedule as mentioned below:

S. N.	IFB No.	Substantially Responsive Bidder	Price Bid opening date and time
1	RE-ICB/DCSD-079/80-16: Supply and Delivery of Truck Mounted Crane	1. Spark Automotives Pvt. Ltd., Nepal	Date: 5 February 2024 Time: 13:00 Hrs

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Life is not a problem to be solved, but a reality to be experienced.
- Soren Kierkegaard

EDITORIAL

Nepal's Standing In NAM

Nepal is one of the founding members of the non-aligned movement (NAM), a group of countries that chose to stay away from major power blocks during the cold war time. Since its establishment in 1961, there have been numerous transformations in the global landscape, such as the fall of the Soviet Union, the formation of NATO, and the emergence of China as a global power. The ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and Israel-Hamas war depict that the Cold War is manifested in other forms. Given the unprecedented challenges in global politics, diplomats frequently question the economic, political, and strategic relevance of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) at a time when power rivalries and conflicts are still going on around the world. However, for a country like Nepal, which is situated between two emerging economic powers, maintaining a balanced and non-aligned foreign policy is considered to be in its best interest.

Nepal has consistently refrained from joining any military alliances and power blocs instead advocates for an inclusive global order where all nations can thrive collectively with a sense of development justice. By adhering to a non-aligned policy, Nepal aims to pursue its national interests while fostering peaceful relations and cooperation with various countries worldwide. Nepal's foreign policy is based on the non-alignment principle, which is enshrined in its constitution. Nepal is committed to maintaining its independence by not aligning itself with any major power bloc.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda on Friday addressed the 19th NAM Summit in Kampala of Uganda where he emphasised the importance of achieving lasting peace in Nepal through the resolution of transitional justice issues. PM Prachanda stresses that Nepal's foreign policy is built on the principles of sovereign equality, mutual respect, and peaceful resolution of disputes. As a leader who emerged from a conflict, he believes that peace is possible and so is addressing historical, sociocultural, and economic injustice both within the nation and globally.

Nepal's foreign policy is based on sovereign equality, mutual respect, mutual benefits, and peaceful settlement of disputes. Stating that Nepal, as a peace-loving country, deplores all kinds of conflict and geo-political rivalries in the world, the Prime Minister described the situation in Ukraine and Gaza as deeply distressing. He expressed his wishes to see peace in the Middle East with a two-state solution for Israel and Palestine, living side by side in peace and security within secured and recognised international borders based on a United Nations resolution.

Amid the doubts on the relevance of the NAM in the present scenario, Prime Minister Prachanda said it can play a crucial role in reforming the global financial architecture to enable countries in special situations to secure finance in achieving their development visions and goals. To provide development justice to these countries, the developed countries must fulfill their financing commitment without delay, the Prime Minister said.

Nonetheless, some of the nations that were in leading roles during the inception of the non-align-movement have themselves drifted away from the ideology of NAM. In this regard, the member countries should work to ensure its relevance so that this forum can evolve into an effective deterrent of war and ensure global peace. In the context of changing global order, non-alignment policy can be Nepal's approach for its meaningful presence as a free and independent nation in the global arena.

Make Tudikhel Visitor-friendly

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

The indigenous men look bold and smart in their traditional attires. Similarly, women appear unique and beautiful with their traditional ornaments and outfits. It is the common characteristic of the indigenous people that when they gather at a public place, they start singing sweet songs and shaking a leg, showing their power and charm. In 'Hamlet', William Shakespeare expresses the beauty and serenity of mankind, "What a piece of work is a man! How noble in reason! How infinite in beauty! In form, in moving, how express and admirable! In action how like an angel! In apprehension how like a god! The beauty of the world! The paragon of animals!''

As Shakespeare says, man, the beautiful creature of the mother earth, should not face any hindrance while celebrating their festivals. Generally, Maghe Sankranti is considered the festival of many ethnic communities in Nepal, but it is the specially the festival of Tharu and Magar communities. Demographically, Tharu community lives in the southern plains, whereas Magar community resides in the mid-hill, but those places lack livelihood opportunities. So, the urban area, especially, Kathmandu Valley, has become the centres of attraction for the young and old of all communities for both survival and progress.

To observe the Maghi, Tharus and Magars in their traditional customs and attires assembled at the Tundikhel with great enthusiasms on 15 January 2024. But, sadly, they suffered a stampede. Over a dozen people were hurt and fortunately no on sustained serious injuries. Tundikhel is a big area. The past administrations deserve kudos for keeping such a large area of land in the middle of the city for public use. But, now it is mismanage. It must be developed and maintained with the present day needs.

It is not good to erect tall and pointed iron pillars around the Tudikhel area with limited number of entrances and exits. It is not a private a property, but the fences around it show, as if, it were an individual property. So, the fence should be reduced to a waist-high as in the past and there should be many entrance and exit gates so that the elderly citizens can benefit from the winter sun and the children can play the games of their choice there. And, the people can celebrate their respective festivals without fear.

Despite haphazard planning, narrow roads and poor services delivery, the Kathmandu Valley is evolving into a mega-city. If the tunnels to Trishuli in Nuwakot and Naubise in Dhanding will come into use and the road widening work in Dhulikhel will be completed, the Kathmandu Valley have to absorb more people. So, the public places should be people-friendly and appropriate for recreational activities.

It is the matter of pride that the Bagmati Province government has announced to construct one open space for public demonstrations in each of the thirteen districts of the Province. All those open places should have wide exit gates, green field and basic amenities.

Anomalies That Beset Left Parties



Ritu Raj Subedi

A few days back, one senior CPN-Maoist Centre leader said that the party was saved from potential disintegration due to its recent drive entitled 'Maoists with People: A Campaign for Special Transformation.' His remark came ahead of its statute convention slated for next month. The term 'disintegration' signifies that the party is facing an existential crisis in the aftermath of the last election, and the campaign sought to reach out to the grassroots to revamp the party by increasing its members and support base.

But what is more noticeable is the use of high-sounding word that the leader chose to portray the situation. Here a question arises – would the party be dissolved if it did not run the nationwide campaign? Perhaps not. The said leader was merely exaggerating the situation. It is true that the Maoist Centre suffered a humiliating defeat in the three-tier elections held in November 2022. But it has not yet reached the point of dissolution. This pen pusher is referring to his statement to highlight the common trait of Nepali communists seen in their speeches, activities and behaviours.

Alarming words

It is customary for them to resort to rhetorical, flamboyant, alarming and arousing terms to stimulate the party rank and file but such lexicons hardly reflect the ground reality. Last week, CPN-UML chair KP Sharma Oli called for launching a movement against the incumbent coalition government to 'protect the country from being ruined'. "Should we sit idle by just saying mission 84 when the nation heads to a disaster? The party functionaries have to join the movement at a short notice," Oli told two separate programmes of the party. Is the country really on the verge of collapse? Does it require a movement to check its imminent fall?

The country is not in a situation as depicted by Oli. Of course, it is struggling to come out of recession and handle a number of issues pertaining to governance, enactment of federal laws, service delivery, unemployment, inflation and corruption control, among others. Being an opposition leader, it is natural for him to slam the government and present a horrifying scenario in order to prepare ground for his rise to power. What is true is that Nepali communist leaders are losing their credibility owing to their series of ideological deviations and a yawning gap between their commitment and performance.

At one point, Oli championed nationalism and on the plank of which he led a Left Alliance to a resounding victory in the 2017 elections. But, when he dissolved the House of Representatives (HoR) twice where the communists held near two-thirds majority, his image as a stanch nationalist leader took a hard knock. So are his nationalistic overtures which barely appeal to the people these days even if they contain truth. With the House dissolution, the voters became disenchanted with mainstream parties, particularly the left and switched to new forces. This has indeed far-reaching repercussions for the communist movement as well as political stability in the country.

> The term 'socialism' is dear to all left groups. But the million-dollar question is: Have they really embraced it in theory and practice barring some random distributive agendas and slogans?

"The government has become comfortable for and bowed before the foreigners on the sensitive subjects such as electricity trade and protection of territory," Oli told newly nominated party's central committee members. However, his statement has not gained much traction among the public. The opposition party has drawn criticisms for not taking a firm stand against various corruption cases and controversial decisions. Oli's attempts to strike a deal on the sharing of seats of National Assembly with the ruling parties have not gone well in the political spectrum.

Being the second largest party, the UML should raise a stronger voice in favour of nationalism, anti-corruption drive and passage of vital federal laws within the parliament. The people are not in a mood to participate in another round of street agitation. Invoking movements and revolutions time and again only degrades their value.

The communist parties are known for preparing thick political and orgnisational reports, holding periodic national conventions, building tight organisational structures, and conducting frequent meetings of their various central bodies. These are necessary for expanding the organisation and electoral base of the parties. However, it is meaningless to conduct rounds of meetings if they do not address people's problems and concerns. They organise a separate convention to write the statute that sets rules, norms, values, behaviours and discipline for running the party. But there are instances in which the statute's provisions turn to dust when they become obstacle to meet the ambition of top leaders.

Distributive slogans

The term 'socialism' is dear to all left groups. But the million-dollar question is: Have they really embraced it in theory and practice barring some random distributive agendas and slogans? Nepal has seen around half a dozen communist prime ministers in the last three decades. But there is no a credible economic roadmap to put the country on robust path of industrialisation. There has been a tendency among the left and non-left governments to compete for announcing the populist programmes without substantive economic base to support them.

The communist party-led governments are supposed to enhance the public sector but there have been little efforts in building socialism-oriented economy as envisaged in the constitution. This is why millions of youths have left the country to toil in foreign labour markets. In practice, the major communist parties have donned neo-liberal garbs and followed western narratives to stay afloat in the national politics, giving a short shrift to their stated goals of communism.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Multipronged Approach Reduces Malnutrition



Dr. Shyam P Lohani

Malnutrition affects millions of people around the world. It is a condition that arises when the body does not get the required nutrients to function properly. Malnutrition can trigger many health problems including stunted growth, weakened immune systems, and even death. Malnutrition is a global health issue that afflicts millions of people worldwide. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), malnutrition is defined as "deficiencies, excesses, or imbalances in a person's intake of energy and/or nutrients." Malnutrition can occur due to various factors that include but are not limited to poverty, lack of access to nutritious food, and underlying health conditions.

Epidemiological studies have revealed that it is a significant public health problem in many parts of the world. In low-income countries, malnutrition is a leading cause of morbidity and mortality, particularly among children under the age of five. The prevalence of malnutrition varies across different regions and populations. In sub-Saharan Africa, for example, an estimated 22 per cent of children under the age of five are underweight, while in South Asia, the prevalence is around 30 per cent.

Risk factors

In developed countries, malnutrition is more prevalent among certain groups, such as the elderly, hospitalised patients, and those with chronic diseases. Much research has also identified various risk factors for malnutrition. Poverty is a significant risk factor, as it limits access to nutritious food and healthcare. Other risk factors include poor sanitation, lack of education, and inadequate maternal and child healthcare. Malnutrition can have significant health consequences, including stunted growth, weakened immune systems, and increased susceptibility to infections.

Moreover, in children, malnutrition can lead to developmental delays and cognitive impairment. In adults, malnutrition can increase the risk of chronic diseases such as diabetes, cardiovascular disease, and cancer. Preventing and treating malnutrition requires a multi-faceted approach that addresses the underlying causes and risk factors. Therefore, improving access to nutritious food, promoting education and healthcare, and addressing poverty and inequality are essential to address it.

There are several ways by the help of which the problem of malnutrition can be addressed. First of all, increasing access to nutritious food is the most effective one. This can be done by promoting the production and distribution of nutrient-rich foods, such as fruits, vegetables, and whole grains. Governments can also provide subsidies to farmers to encourage them to grow these foods. Additionally, food banks and other charitable organizations can distribute food to those in need.

Another way to tackle malnutrition is to improve education on nutrition. Many people do not know what foods are nutritious and how to prepare them. By providing education on nutrition, people can learn how to make healthy food choices and prepare nutritious meals. This can be done through community programmes, schools, and healthcare facilities. In this regard, school health education is one of the most important ways of tackling it. It is important to note that the revision of the curriculum if need be, can be an important beginning.

> Addressing poverty can help to reduce malnutrition. This can be done through programmes that provide job training, education, and financial assistance.

In some cases, people may not be able to get all the nutrients they need from food alone. In these cases, nutritional supplements can be provided. This can include vitamins, minerals, and other nutrients that are essential for good health. Nutritional supplements can be provided through healthcare facilities or community programs. The role of the Female Community Health Volunteer (FCHV) cannot be undermined in the Nepalese context. Poverty is a major contributor to malnutrition. People who live in poverty may not have access to nutritious food or the resources to purchase it. Addressing poverty can help to reduce malnutrition. This can be done through programmes that provide job training, education, and financial assistance.

Healthcare facilities can provide screening and treatment for malnutrition. They can also provide education on nutrition and refer patients to community programmes that provide nutritious food and supplements. Identifying severe acute malnutrition (SAM) and moderately acute malnutrition (MAM) at the household levels by FCHV becomes important. Healthcare providers also play a crucial role in identifying and treating malnutrition, particularly in high-risk populations.

Nepal government has initiated the Multi-Sectoral Nutritional Policy (MSNP) that aims at addressing the issue of malnutrition in Nepal. It recognises that malnutrition is a complex problem that requires a multi-sectoral approach involving various government ministries, civil society organizations, and other stakeholders. The policy focuses on improving nutrition outcomes through a range of interventions, including improving access to nutritious food, promoting breastfeeding and complementary feeding practices, enhancing nutrition education and awareness, and strengthening the capacity of health systems to deliver nutrition services.

Collaboration

The MSNP also emphasises the importance of collaboration and coordination among different sectors, such as health, agriculture, education, and social welfare, to address the underlying causes of malnutrition and ensure a comprehensive approach. Overall, the Multi-Sectoral Nutritional Policy is seen as a positive step towards addressing the issue of malnutrition in the country. By adopting a multi-sectoral approach, it aims to tackle the problem from various angles and improve the nutritional status of the population.

In conclusion, malnutrition is a serious problem that requires a multi-faceted approach. By increasing access to nutritious food, improving education on nutrition, providing nutritional supplements, addressing poverty, and improving healthcare, we can work towards reducing malnutrition and improving the health of millions of people around the world. Thus, by working together, we can improve the health and well-being of millions of people affected by malnutrition worldwide.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at the Health Concern. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 21, 1974

Martyrs Day Committee

Lalitpur, June 20: A nine-member committee has been constituted to observe the Martyrs Day here on January 29, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

Fund Facilitates Girl Education

This refers to news report *'Girl child to be granted cash'* published in the online edition of this daily on Saturday. As per the report, Kaligandaki Rural Municipality in Gulmi district has introduced a policy to deposit Rs. 10,000 in the account of each baby girl born in the rural municipality.

The municipality's policy seeks to facilitate the girls to pursue their higher education. The fund will increase around Rs. 40,000 by the time they become eligible to withdraw it. There is a provision requiring that only the account holder can withdraw the fund after obtaining the citizenship certificate.

As the municipality has already endorsed the working procedures, it will not face any obstacle in implementing the popular scheme. Approximately 40 girls were born in the rural municipality in the past fiscal year and its Health Department has received applications from 20 girls born in the current fiscal year.



This is indeed a positive step in the direction of empowering girls and women in the society. The municipality deserves kudos for this initiative that can be replicated in other parts of the country.

Radhika Thapa
Pokhara

TAILPIECE

Jack, a handsome man, walked into a sports bar around 9:58 pm. He sat down next to this blonde at the bar and stared up at the TV...

The 10:00 news was on. The news crew was covering a story of a man on a ledge of a large building preparing to jump. The blonde looked at Jack and said, 'Do you think he'll jump?' Jack says, 'You know what, I bet he will.' The blonde replied, 'Well, I bet he won't.' Jack placed $30 on the bar and said, 'You're on!'

Just as the blonde placed her money on the bar, the guy did a swan dive off of the building, falling to his death. The blonde was very upset and handed her $30 to Jack, saying, 'Fair's fair... Here's your money.' Jack replied, 'I can't take your money, I saw this earlier on the 5 o'clock news and knew he would jump.

'The blonde replies, 'I did too; but I didn't think he'd do it again.' Jack took the money.

Deadly Israeli strike on Damascus targets Iran's Revolutionary Guards

AFP
Beirut, Jan. 20



PHOTO: AFP

People and security forces gather in front of a building destroyed in a reported Israeli strike in Damascus on January 20.

An Israeli strike on Damascus killed five people in a building where "Iran-aligned leaders" were meeting on Saturday, a war monitor said, as regional tensions soar over the Israel-Hamas war.

"An Israeli missile strike targeted a four-storey building, killing five people... and destroying the whole building where Iran-aligned leaders were meeting," said the Syrian Observatory for Human Rights.

The British-based monitor with a network of sources inside Syria said the targeted neighbourhood is known to be a high-security zone home to leaders of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and pro-Iran Palestinian factions.

"They were for sure targeting senior members" of those groups, said Observatory director Rami Abdel Rahman.

The mid-morning strike, which caused a large plume of smoke to billow into the sky, was also reported by Syrian state media.

"An attack targeted a residential building in the Mazzeh neighbourhood in Damascus, resulting from an Israeli aggression," the official SANA news agency reported. It did not say if there were any casualties.

An AFP correspondent at the scene said the destroyed building was cordoned off with ambulances, firefighters and Syrian Arab Red Crescent rescue teams all present at the site.

Civil defence were busy searching for survivors under the rubble of the totally collapsed building, he said.

The Mazzeh area is also home to the United Nations' headquarters, embassies and restaurants.

"I heard the explosion clearly in the western Mazzeh area, and I saw a large cloud of smoke," a resident told AFP.

"The sound was similar to a missile explosion, and minutes later I heard the sound of ambulances," he added.

During more than a decade of civil war in Syria, Israel has launched hundreds of air strikes on its territory, primarily targeting Iran-backed forces as well as Syrian army positions.

But it has intensified attacks since the war between Israel and Hamas, which like Lebanon's Hezbollah movement is an ally of Iran, began on October 7.

In December, an Israeli air strike killed a senior general with Iran's Revolutionary Guards, the military force said.

Razi Moussavi was the most senior commander of the Guards' foreign operations arm, the Quds Force, to be killed outside Iran since a US drone strike in Baghdad on January 3, 2020 killed the Force's commander, Qasem Soleimani.

In the same month, air strikes in eastern Syria, "likely" carried out by Israel, killed at least 23 pro-Iran fighters, the Observatory said at the time, reporting four more dead in the country's north.

Recent months have also seen regular cross-border exchanges of fire between Israel and Hezbollah in southern Lebanon.

Israel rarely comments on individual strikes targeting Syria, but it has repeatedly said it will not allow arch foe Iran, which backs President Bashar al-Assad's government, to expand its presence there.

Japanese lunar probe lands on Moon

AFP
Tokyo, Jan. 20



PHOTO: AFP

A miniature model of the Smart Lander for Investigating Moon (SLIM) is displayed at Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA)'s facility in Sagamihara, Japan, January 19, 2024.

Japan became on Saturday only the fifth nation to achieve a "soft landing" on the Moon, but its space agency said that the craft's solar cells were not generating power.

With the Smart Lander for Investigating Moon (SLIM), Japan followed the United States, the Soviet Union, China and most recently India in achieving the feat.

JAXA confirmed that the SLIM "landed on the Moon at 00:20 am on 20 January 2024 (Japan Time). Communication has been established since landing," JAXA said.

"However, the solar cells are not generating power and data acquisition from the lunar surface is given priority," it added.

"The SLIM is operated with on-board batteries. The data acquired on landing is stored in the spacecraft, and we are currently working to maximise the scientific results by first transmitting this data back to Earth," said JAXA official Hitoshi Kuninaka.

Japan's mission is one of a string of new projects launched in recent years on the back of renewed interest in Earth's natural satellite.

If all went to plan, it will have landed within a target area just 100 metres (yards) across, far tighter than the usual landing zone of several kilometres (miles).

Success would restore high-tech Japan's reputation in space after two failed lunar missions and recent rocket failures, including explosions after take-off.

It would also echo the triumph of India's low-cost space programme in August, when it became the first to land an unscrewed craft near the Moon's largely unexplored south pole.

Japan's space agency JAXA has already made a pinpoint landing on an asteroid, but the challenge is greater on the Moon, where gravity is stronger.

SLIM was meant to try to reach a crater where the Moon's mantle -- the usually deep inner layer beneath its crust -- is believed to be accessible at the surface.

This includes shedding light on the mystery of the Moon's possible water resources, which will also be key to building bases there one day as possible stopovers on the way to Mars.

"The possibility of lunar commercialisation depends on whether there is water at the poles," Morota said.

More than 50 years after the first human Moon landing, many countries and private companies are attempting to make the trip anew.

But crash-landings, communication failures and other technical problems are rife.

13 STUDENTS KILLED IN DORM FIRE IN HENAN PROVINCE

AP
Bangkok, Jan. 20

A fire broke out in dorms at a boarding school for elementary students in central Henan province, and 13 students died in the blaze, Chinese state media reported Saturday.

All of the dead were third grade students, a teacher told Zonglan news, a state-backed media outlet from Hebei province. One person rescued from the scene was being treated in the hospital, CCTV, China's state broadcaster said.

The fire started Friday night and was put out just before midnight at Yingcai School in rural Fangcheng district in central Henan, and the school's owner was detained, CCTV reported.

Local authorities said they were investigating the cause of the fire.

The boarding school caters primarily to students in the elementary grades, though it has an attached kindergarten, according to the school's WeChat page. Many of the boarding students come from rural areas, the Beijing Youth Daily reported.

The facility is in Dushu township and is one of the school's two branches.

Rifts emerge among Israeli officials over handling war

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 20



PHOTO: AP

Relatives and supporters of the Israeli hostages held in the Gaza Strip by the Hamas militant group attend a march calling for their release, in Tel Aviv, Israel, Friday, Jan. 19, 2024.

A member of Israel's War Cabinet cast doubt on the country's strategy for releasing hostages held by Hamas, saying only a cease-fire can free them, as the prime minister rejected the United States' calls to scale back its offensive.

The comments by Gadi Eisenkot, a former army chief, marked the latest sign of disagreement among top Israeli officials over the direction of the war against Hamas, now in its fourth month.

In his first public statements on the course of the war, Eisenkot said that claims the dozens of hostages could be freed by means other than a cease-fire amounted to spreading "illusions" — an implicit criticism of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who heads the five-member War Cabinet and who insists that pursuing the war will win their release.

Eisenkot's statements came as some relatives of hostages have intensified their protests, a sign of mounting frustration over the government's seeming lack of progress toward a deal to release the remaining captives.

Eli Shtivi, whose 28-year-old son Idan has been held in Gaza since he was kidnapped by Hamas militants from the open-air Tribe of Nova music festival on Oct. 7., began a hunger strike Friday night outside Netanyahu's private residence in the coastal town of Caesarea. Shtivi pledged to eat only a quarter of a pita a day — the reported daily meal of the hostages — until the prime minister agrees to meet with him. Dozens of people joined him for what organizers said was an overnight protest.

The day before, rifle-toting Israeli police scuffled with protesters who blocked a major highway in Tel Aviv to call for an immediate deal to release the hostages. Police detained seven protesters overnight, according to Israeli media.

Meanwhile, communications began to gradually return in Gaza after a nearly eight-day blackout, the longest such cutoff since the war began. The phone and internet blackout made it nearly impossible for people in Gaza to communicate with the outside world or within the territory, hampering deliveries of humanitarian aid and rescue efforts amid continued Israeli bombardment.

For the past week, Gaza residents have struggled to get a signal on their phones. Many head to the beach, where some can pick up a non-Palestinian network. With families scattered across the tiny Mediterranean territory, networks are critical to make sure relatives are still alive as Israeli airstrikes crush homes.

"The people behind me came to check on their friends, family and loved ones," said Karam Mezre, referring to others sitting with him on a rock at the beach in central Gaza, scanning their phones.

Even when communications return, "it is intermittent and not stable," said Hamza Al-Barasi, who was displaced from Gaza City.

The blackout has also made it difficult for information to get out of Gaza on the daily death and destruction from Israel's offensive. The assault has pulverized much of the Gaza Strip, home to some 2.3 million people, as Israel vows to crush Hamas after its unprecedented Oct. 7 raid into Israel. In the attack, about 1,200 people, mostly civilians, were killed and 250 others taken hostage. Israel has said more than 130 hostages remain in Gaza, but not all of them are believed to be alive.

Israel's offensive, one of the deadliest and most destructive military campaigns in recent history, has killed nearly 25,000 Palestinians, according to Gaza health authorities, and uprooted more than 80% of the territory's population.

PRISM

Chicagoans work to preserve 'rat hole'

Chicago: Chicago's famous "rat hole," a rodent-shaped indentation in a concrete sidewalk, was filled in by an unknown person, leading fans to attempt to exhume the landmark.

The "rat hole," an indentation left when the cement was still wet in the 1900 block of West Roscoe Street in the 1990s, became a viral phenomenon this month when fans started posting photos and videos to social media.

Visitors left "offerings" including spare change and snacks as tribute to "Chimley," the name given to the animal that created the indentation.

The hole appeared to be rat-shaped, but some neighbours and animal experts said it was more likely left by a small squirrel that fell out of a tree.

Fans gathered at the rat hole on Friday discovered it had been filled in overnight with a concrete or plaster-like substance. Visitors worked to dig the still-wet substance out of the hole to preserve the landmark.

Amorous fish blamed for mysterious sound

Florida: A Florida scientist said a mysterious bass sound reported by residents in the Tampa Bay area might be coming from mating fish.

Area residents reported hearing the low-pitched sound periodically since 2021, and so far no concrete answers have been found as to its origins.

James Locascio, a senior scientist with the Mote Marine Laboratory and Aquarium, said the sound could be coming from black drum fish in the bay. He said the fish produce throbbing sounds during their mating season when muscles vibrate against their swim bladders.

He said the sound could reach as far as a mile away from the water.

(Agencies)

US hospitalisations with respiratory illnesses amid cold surge

AP
New York, Jan. 20

Winter is here, inflicting its usual array of symptoms — coughs, nasal congestion, fatigue and fever — and, this year, a new COVID-19 variant is dominating the scoreboard.

COVID-19 is leading hospital admissions among the respiratory viruses, according to the U.S. Centres for Disease Control and Prevention.

Last week, 25 U.S. states had high or very high levels for respiratory illnesses with fever, cough and other symptoms. That's down from 37 states the week before, the CDC said.

Since the beginning of October, there have been at least 16 million illnesses, 180,000 hospitalizations, and 11,000 deaths from flu so far this season. The CDC said 47 children have died of flu.

January can be the worst month for these illnesses. With vaccination rates low, what can you do to protect yourself from respiratory viruses, including influenza, COVID-19 and RSV?

Hand-washing remains crucial to reducing the spread of viral infections. Take your time at the sink. Twenty seconds is recommended. If you feel silly singing "Happy Birthday" twice while you scrub with soapy water, count to 20. Slowly.

Use hand sanitizer with 60% alcohol when you don't have access to soap and water.

Also, wear a mask in crowded areas. Increase ventilation in your workplace and home.

In the United States, only 17% of those eligible have received the updated COVID-19 vaccine, which provides good protection against the now-dominant JN.1 variant.

It's not too late to roll up your sleeve. While you're at it, make sure you've had your annual flu shot. Those 60 and older may want to get the RSV vaccine, which also is recommended during pregnancy to prevent RSV in infants.

Young children seem to pick up every germ going around. Can their parents avoid getting sick?



FILE PHOTO: AP

A pedestrian wears a heavy coat against the cold in New York, Tuesday, Jan. 11, 2022. January can be the worst month for respiratory illnesses and vaccination rates are low.

This time of year, children are indoors in close quarters with other kids, touching the same toys and surfaces, said Jennifer Sonney of University of Washington School of Nursing in Seattle. Some haven't learned to cover their coughs and they simply haven't been exposed to many illnesses, so their immune systems are still developing.

It's important to take care of yourself if you're a parent or caregiver of young children, said Sonney who is immediate past president of the National Association of Pediatric Nurse Practitioners.

"We know if you are sleep deprived or dehydrated or experiencing a lot of stress, that can compromise your immune function," Sonney said.

Having young children is very demanding, "so all of this advice needs to be interpreted within the context of reality," she said. "Despite doing everything right, kids are still going to get colds."

A special note if your baby is sick: It's a good idea to have saline drops and a bulb syringe at home. They can be used to clear mucus from tiny nostrils.

TODAY IN HISTORY

763 – Following the Battle of Bakhamra between Alids and Abbasids near Kufa, the Alid rebellion ends with the death of Ibrahim, brother of Isa ibn Musa.

1749 – The Teatro Filarmonico in Verona is destroyed by fire, as a result of a torch being left behind in the box of a nobleman after a performance. It is rebuilt in 1754.

1774 – Abdul Hamid I becomes Sultan of the Ottoman Empire and Caliph of Islam.

1793 – After being found guilty of treason by the French National Convention, Louis XVI of France is executed by guillotine.

1954 – The first nuclear-powered submarine, the USS Nautilus, is launched in Groton, Connecticut by Mamie Eisenhower, the First Lady of the United States.

19.5 KM BLACKTOPPED ALONG MUGLIN-POKHARA ROAD EXPANSION

RSS
Damauli, Jan. 20

Under the ongoing Muglin-Pokhara road expansion project, 19.5 km road has been blacktopped. The blacktopping is done from Anbukhaireni to Bandipur of Tanahu district.

Engineer mobilised under the project, Bishnu Prasad Pande, informed that among the blacktopping, there is a two-way pitch in 7.2 km distance.

The blacktopping is now undergoing at Baradi section. It would be carried out on both sides, he added.

The locals and travelers had complained that dusty road had caused sheer inconvenience.

Similarly, a motorable bridge in arc design is being constructed over the Madi River. The bridge, connecting Byas municipality ward no 4 and 5 is constructed at the cost of Rs 210 million.

The Muglin-Pokhara road expansion project is going on with contracts in two phases.

COORDINATION COMMITTEE TO FACILITATE NA ELECTION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

A meeting of the National Assembly Election Central Coordination Committee-2024 of the ruling parties on Saturday decided to visit provinces of the country to coordinate and facilitate the National Assembly election going to be held on January 25.

Issuing a press statement, Keshav Raj Joshi, Secretary of the National Assembly Election Central Coordination Committee, informed that candidates of all seven provinces discussed about the upcoming election during the meeting.

Similarly, the meeting also directed the National Assembly Provincial Coordination Committee and District Coordination Committee to implement the decision.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Pachali Bhairav dance being performed at Lagan of Kathmandu on Saturday. The dance known as 'Shree Pachali Bhairav Khadga Siddhi Nach' takes place in an interval of 12 years.

Nikki Haley has spent 20 years navigating Republican

AP
Washington, Jan. 20

When Nikki Haley was a South Carolina legislator, she backed budgets boosted by federal aid. Running for governor, she criticized a "bailout culture" and dependence on Washington.

She once called the Confederate battle flag a heritage symbol and sidestepped calls to remove it from statehouse grounds. After a racist massacre in Charleston, Haley moved to take it down.

When Donald Trump ran for president in 2016, she opposed him before joining his administration as U.N. ambassador. Now, Haley is running against Trump for the 2024 Republican nomination saying he is an agent of chaos.

For almost 20 years, Haley has worked to navigate Republicans' rightward march, trying to cultivate both the GOP establishment and the firebrand conservative base that gave rise



to Trump. She is seen as either a pragmatic unifier or a finger-to-the-wind politician, and as she seeks the Republican nomination, her political pivots have become her opponents' most persistent line of attack.

"Maybe she can be a bit of a chameleon," said former state Rep. Doug Brannon, a fellow Republican. "The governor and I did not get along," he said, "but that doesn't mean that she isn't a brilliant politician."

Shapeshifting is a long-practiced political art. Bill Clinton earned the nickname "Slick Willie" and won two terms in the White House. Trump went from being emphatically supportive of abortion rights to telling voters he alone was responsible for the Supreme Court decision overturning Roe v. Wade, winning over white evangelicals.

In the 2024 campaign, Haley has leaned into her critics. Trump skipping debates has meant she and the former president have not confronted each other face to face but she has forcefully defended herself against his suggestions that she is out of step with today's Republican Party.

"For those reporting that I'm a moderate, I will ask you or anybody, Trump or anybody in Fox (News) suits saying that I'm not a conservative: Name one thing that I wasn't conservative about," she said Friday in New Hampshire.

She offered a litany of measures she signed as governor to lower taxes, boost voter identification requirements and overhaul public employee pensions, among other matters.

Microsoft says state-backed Russian hackers accessed emails of senior leadership team members

AP
Boston, Jan. 20:

State-backed Russian hackers broke into Microsoft's corporate email system and accessed the accounts of members of the company's leadership team, as well as those of employees on its cybersecurity and legal teams, the company said Friday.

In a blog post, Microsoft said the intrusion began in late November and was discovered on Jan. 12. It said the same highly skilled Russian hacking team behind the SolarWinds breach was responsible.

"A very small percentage" of Microsoft corporate accounts were accessed, the company said, and some emails and attached documents were stolen.

A company spokesperson said Microsoft had no immediate comment on which or how many members of its senior leadership had their email accounts breached. In a regulatory filing Friday, Microsoft said it was able to remove the hackers' access from the compromised accounts on or about Jan. 13.

"We are in the process of notifying



employees whose email was accessed," Microsoft said, adding that its investigation indicates the hackers were initially targeting email accounts for information related to their activities.

The Microsoft disclosure comes a month after a new U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission rule took effect that compels publicly traded companies to disclose breaches that could negatively impact their business. It gives them four days to do so unless they obtain a national-security waiver.

In Friday's SEC regulatory filing, Microsoft said that "as of the date of this filing, the incident has not had a material impact" on its operations. It added that it has not, however, "determined whether the incident is reasonably likely to materially impact" its finances.

Microsoft, which is based in Redmond, Washington, said the hackers from Russia's SVR foreign intelligence agency were able to gain access by compromising credentials on a "legacy" test account, suggesting it had outdated code. After gaining a foothold, they used the account's permissions to access the accounts of the senior leadership team and others. The brute-force attack technique used by the hackers is called "password spraying."

The threat actor uses a single common password to try to log into multiple accounts. In an August blog post, Microsoft described how its threat-intelligence team discovered that the same Russian hacking team had used the technique to try to steal credentials from at least 40 different global organizations through Microsoft Teams chats.

"The attack was not the result of a vulnerability in Microsoft products or services," the company said in the blog. "To date, there is no evidence that the threat actor had any access to customer environments, production systems, source code, or AI systems. We will notify customers if any action is required."

Microsoft calls the hacking unit Midnight Blizzard. Prior to revamping its threat-actor nomenclature last year, it called the group Nobelium. The cybersecurity firm Mandiant, owned by Google, calls the group Cozy Bear.

In a 2021 blog post, Microsoft called the SolarWinds hacking campaign "the most sophisticated nation-state attack in history." In addition to U.S. government agencies, including the departments of Justice and Treasury, more than 100 private companies and think tanks were compromised, including software and telecommunications providers.

'Expedite construction of Beni-Jomsom-Korala road'

RSS
Myagdi, Jan. 20

Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala has directed the stakeholders to expedite the development of Beni-Jomsom-Korala road section of the national pride Kaligandaki corridor.

During an inspection visit to the site on Saturday, Minister Jwala directed the contractors to speed up the construction jobs adding that 'everyone's attention is drawn to the dillydallying in the national pride Kaligandaki corridor'.

The Minister shared that the monitoring was done to explore the key reason behind the slow progress in the project and assured to hold discussions soon with the concerned bodies to ensure speedy construction of the road section.

Minister Jwala, who arrived here along with Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Management of Gandaki Province Resham Bahadur Jugjali and other officials from the federal and province governments, visited the landside-hit areas at Baisari and Sirubari in Raghuganga Rural Municipality-2, Myagdi.

The estimated cost of the project is Rs 7.55 billion and a total of Rs 6 billion plus has already been spent till the last fiscal year.

So far, 85 kms of the road section has been graveled and 19 kms is blacktopped and 18 motorable bridges and three belly bridges were also completed, Project Chief Dhruba Jha said.

House demolition begins in Damauli for road expansion

RSS
Tanahun, Jan 20

Demolition of houses along the eastern section of Muglin-Pokhara road has begun in Damauli Bazar area, the district headquarters of Tanahun.

Out of a total of 70 houses to be demolished, 45 families have started demolishing themselves after receiving first installment.

Engineer Bsishnu Prasad Pandey of Muglin-Pokhara eastern section said that the second installment will be paid after demolishing the house.

According to him, around Rs 60 million will be spent to compensate the houses in Damauli market area. "If everyone takes the first phase of compensation, 60 per cent will be distributed," he said, adding that the houses in Damauli market area are expected to be demolished within the next one-and-a-half months.

According to him, work would be carried out in Damauli Bazar area after expansion of the road from Dumre Bazaar area in Bandipur rural municipality of the district.

He said that the project is urging them to demolish the house, holding meetings from time to time and encouraging the municipality to demolish the house as the owners themselves are demolishing the houses.

Brutally cold weather expected to hit storm-battered South and Northeast US this weekend

AP
Memphis, Jan. 20

Memphis residents were urged to boil water and New Yorkers have been warned that roads could be covered with dangerous black ice this weekend as brutal cold and inclement weather continue to sweep across parts of the U.S.

Bitterly frigid air spilled into the Midwest from Canada on Friday and several states were under advisories as forecasters warned that wind chills dipping to minus 30 degrees Fahrenheit (minus 34 degrees Celsius) could be common through Sunday morning.

Heavier-than-forecast snow fell in New York City, Baltimore and Washington, D.C., on Friday. Storms have walloped the Pacific Northwest, Midwest, Plains, South and Northeast with low temperatures, heavy snow, ice storms, freezing rain and high winds for the past two weeks.

With a wind chill, temperatures are expected to drop as low as 15 degrees below zero Fahrenheit (minus 26 degrees Celsius) in large portions of Arkansas, Mississippi, Missouri, Tennessee, Kentucky and Kansas, the National Weather Service predicted.

The bracing weekend weather follows a series of storms blamed for at least 55 deaths around the country, many of them involving hypothermia or road accidents.

Tennessee recorded 19 deaths alone. They included a 25-year-old man who was found dead on the floor of a mobile home in Lewisburg after a space heater overturned and turned off, said Bob Johnson, chief deputy for the Marshall County Sheriff's Office.

"There was ice on the walls in there," Johnson said.

Days of cold broke so many water mains in Memphis, Tennessee, that water pressure fell throughout the city. On Friday, Memphis Light, Gas & Water urged all of its more than 400,000 residents to boil water for drinking or teeth brushing or use bottled supplies.

It wasn't clear how long the advisory will be in force. While some 50 ruptures were repaired, utility President Doug McGowen warned of new leaks emerging.

A significant drop in blood donations, partly linked to the weather, led Blood Assurance to recommend that more than 70 hospitals in five states halt elective surgeries until Wednesday to allow inventory to be rebuilt by the organization based in Chattanooga, Tennessee.

In West Virginia, advisories and warnings were out Saturday because of continued fierce weather. The weather service said some regions could see up to 4 inches (10 centimeters) of additional snow with winds gusting to 40 mph (64 kph) and wind chill driving down temperatures as low as 20 below zero (minus 29 C).

The West Virginia Legislature left after a brief session Friday because not enough lawmakers could get through snow-covered highways to the Capitol to vote on bills.In Washington D.C., snow fell softly and the streets around the U.S. Capitol were silent.

Schools closed for the second time in a week and the federal government was on a two-hour delay. However, President Joe Biden still welcomed mayors from around the country to the White House for the U.S. Conference of Mayors.

In Buffalo, New York, lake-enhanced snow finally moved out after burying parts of the city and some suburbs in five feet of snow in five days.

Experts suggest building quake-resilient housing settlement using local materials and...

that the number of beneficiaries identified till January 18, 2024, has increased compared to 67,000 beneficiaries earlier. Adhikari said that the Authority had previously estimated that the number of beneficiaries would reach 80,150, but now it has remained around the same.

According to the official, the government has so far disbursed Rs. 2.26 billion to the beneficiaries. It is estimated that Rs. 4.75 billion would be needed for their temporary housing. Based on that, more funds are still needed.

According to CEO Pokhrel, as of January 18, Rs. 1.90 billion has been transferred to the the Local-level Disaster Management Committees through the District Disaster Management Fund by the federal government. And of the sent budget (Rs. 1.90 billion), Rs. 1.26 billion has reached to the accounts of concerned beneficiaries, he said.

According to him, the disbursed amount has reached the accounts of 50,000 beneficiaries. Among them, construction of temporary housing for 24,000 beneficiaries has just been completed, CEO Pokhrel said.

He said that 10,000 houses are currently under construction. Of the rest of the families, the grant agreement is in the stage of being sealed.

The NDRRMA has estimated that Rs. 73 billion will be needed for reconstruction of the damaged infrastructure in Jajarkot, Rukum West, and other districts of western Nepal.

There is a need for coordination between all levels of government and all related agencies, he said. Pokhrel said that the Authority is ready to lead the reconstruction campaign as a central coordinating body.

Proposed reconstruction modalities

As proposed by the NDRRMA, there are some modalities to be taken into consideration. According to CEO Pokhrel, when we talk about making earthquake-resistant structure, many of us have a habit of assuming only the houses built using concrete and big rods. However, a safe house can also be made using local materials such as finely cut and flat shape stones and wood.

Looking at the houses damaged by the last and this year's earthquakes in West Nepal, the houses with round and oval stones, and mud joints with no ties or interlocking system are more badly damaged. But the houses that have used and made of flat stones have been comparatively less damaged, he said.

Therefore, a quake-resistant house can be made by cutting and giving required shapes to the stones available at the local level, and using woods and bamboos. The Krishna temple in Lalitpur Patan, built hundreds of years ago using stone, is still standing before us as a living relic, said CEO Pokhrel.

Public infrastructures that were damaged by the November 3 quake in Jajarkot can be built by the concerned thematic unit and under the leadership of the province government. Similarly, the private housing can be built under the leadership of the local level governments as described in the Integrated Subsidy Work Procedure Prepared for Monsoon Disaster Affected Private Housing Reconstruction and Rehabilitation-2021. He also said that reconstruction work can also be carried out according to national standards (as proposed by the Department of Urban Development and Building Construction) under the Karnali and Sudurpaschim province governments.

He said that the NDRRMA has done necessary homework and prepared some modalities of reconstruction and rehabilitation of private and public housing damaged by the recent quakes.

Some of the modalities include Green, Resilient, and Inclusive Development Pathway (GRID), which is the most demanded and chosen model by the donor partners of Nepal, owner driven modality, build back better approach, community partnership, and in-situ construction approach, the construction which is carried out at the building site using raw materials.

Similarly, other modalities include local government-led modality, provisioning concessional financing model, technical and financial support from provincial and federal government, and collaboration with I/NGOs and private sectors.

However, according to the CEO Pokhrel, Cabinet approval is necessary for which modality to be adopted for the reconstruction among many models proposed by the NDRRMA. It has not yet confirmed which modality will be implemented for the reconstruction of private housing in Jajarkot, Rukum West and other districts this time, he said.

Total funds required for reconstruction

According to the projection of the NDRRMA, if the total beneficiary houses reach 95,787 in Jajarkot and other adjoining districts of Karnali and Sudurpaschim provinces, it might cost Rs. 72.45 billion for the purpose. Of them, Rs. 52 billion is required for the private house reconstruction alone if built by adopting build back better model. Earthquake that struck in different dates this year had also hit Salyan, Bajura and Bajhang districts, apart from Jajarkot and Rukum West.

Reconstruction subsidy

As per the Work Procedure, quake victims in the hills are eligible to get a sum of Rs. 500,000, Rs. 400,000 in mountains and Rs. 300,000 in the Tarai region for the reconstruction of private housing. Those whose houses need just minor repair or retrofitting, will receive Rs. 50,000 collectively after completing the task only. Such subsidies are available in a total of three tranches.

Space Publishes New India Tour MV

BY MANNU SHAHI



Space is a post-rock/ progressive quintet thriving in the local alternative-art music scene of Kathmandu since 2016. The band initiated their journey as a solo project of guitarist and band leader Riken Maharjan and later brewed into this stellar collective adored by their devoted pack of followers.

Riken released his solo five-track EP "Space" (2016) on SoundCloud, a free music streaming platform, and later the same year aligned forces with friends Season Maharjan on drums and Nikita Shrestha on vocals to perform his tunes live at a concert organised by the Music Circle Institute. This was their earliest formation. But, in a couple of months, Abhinav Lama on bass and Rojib Shahi on guitars joined the bill and Space performed their debut full-band event at Fete De La Musique 2016 held at the Alliance Française.

In 2017, the band appeared on the second season of the Yomari Sessions, performing four singles live from their debut album, of which the romantically infused pop-rock ballad 'Hallucinating' received generous appreciation. This cemented the quintet as a formidable act in the digital realms too.

The live sessions showcased their first ever line-up change with popular musician Kobid Bazra filling in the lower-end duties. This line-up of Space went on to record their debut nine-track LP, "Eye/I" (2018).

"Eye/I" features two instrumental tunes alongside seven English numbers, ranging from catchy pop anthems and minimalist guitar driven melodies to progressive song structures and alternating rhythmic variations. The LP traces influences from their beloved musicians such as the American rock group Paramore and the Japanese math rock quartet Toe.

This was followed by a couple years of performance-driven routine with back-to-back shows and tours across the country, as well as live collaborations. However, in the same period, drummer Season left the group and was replaced by Bikesh Bajracharya. Similarly, Ritavrat Joshi was also brought on board as the new bassist.

Subsequent to this, Space published their sophomore entry "Kapaas" (2022) comprising six tracks justifying their evolving compositional caliber. Around the launch and recording of this album, guitarist Rojib, who was traveling to and from the country due to his personal endeavors, was occasionally seen replaced by new ax-man Nir Khadka, who also contributes on a few tracks in the album.

Contrary to their debut, all of the six songs featured in "Kapaas" were penned in Nepali by vocalist Nikita and bassist Ritavrat. This entry exhibits the band delving deeper in the progressive side of their artistry and the production is also executed with more finesse. Post this album, the band has been releasing videos for individual tracks, playing abundant shows and also published a live performance of the first single from their fabricating third studio album.

And last Wednesday, on January 17, Space dropped a music video for their fourth single 'Maya' from the sophomore entry. The video shot during their recent cross-border tour across six cities in India - New Delhi, Kolkata, Goa, Darjeeling, Sikkim and Kalimpong, subtly portrays the perks of meaningful friendships, teamwork and traveling.

The band is seen enjoying each other's company, living their hard-earned dreams, venturing into a new found state of perseverance and acceptance, fooling around and being themselves. As suggested by its title the song describes feelings of love, optimism and hope. The complementing music feels like an aesthetically pleasing experience wrapped along a heartwarming video bursting goofy ease and intimacy. A commendable execution indeed!

Japan's imperial family hosts poetry reading to welcome new year



AP
Tokyo, Jan. 20

A mother's love and a yearning for peace flowed from Japanese Empress Masako's poem, read Friday at an annual celebration of poetry at the Imperial Palace in Tokyo.

The poem sings of how Masako was touched by what her daughter, Princess Aiko, wrote after her school trip to the southern Japanese city of Hiroshima, which was devastated by an atomic bomb in the closing days of World War II.

Starting the new year with poetry is part of Japanese culture. The gathering at the palace is believed to have begun in the 13th century, according to the Imperial Household Agency. Among the guests wearing suits, kimono and other formalwear were people who had won awards for their own poems.

Various works written in traditional "waka" style were presented Friday, solemnly read aloud in a sing-song way, like a chant, as the imperial family watched. Waka — literally meaning Japanese-style song — is short-form poetry that usually follows a 5-7-5-7-7 syllable format.

Meanwhile, Emperor Naruhito's poem affirmed the idea of peace by describing seeing the smiles of all the people during his travels throughout Japan. Naruhito, grandson of the wartime emperor Hirohito, and his family are fairly popular, greeted by waving crowds wherever they go.

Grand jury indicts Baldwin in 2021 shooting of cinematographer

AP
Santa Fe, Jan. 20

A grand jury indicted Alec Baldwin on Friday on an involuntary manslaughter charge in a 2021 fatal shooting during a rehearsal on a movie set in New Mexico, reviving a dormant case against the actor.

Special prosecutors brought the case before a grand jury in Santa Fe this week, months after receiving a new analysis of the gun that was used. They declined to answer questions after spending about a day and a half presenting their case to the grand jury.

Defence attorneys for Baldwin indicated they'll fight the charge.

"We look forward to our day in court," said Luke Nikas and Alex Spiro, attorneys for Baldwin, in an email.

While the proceeding is shrouded in secrecy, two of the witnesses seen at the courthouse included crew members — one who was present when the fatal shot was fired and another who had walked off the set the day before due to safety concerns.

Baldwin, the lead actor and a co-producer on the Western movie 'Rust,' was pointing a gun at cinematographer Halyna Hutchins during a rehearsal on a movie set outside Santa Fe in October 2021 when the gun went off, killing her and wounding director Joel Souza.

Baldwin has said he pulled back the hammer, but not the trigger, and the gun fired.

The charge has again put Baldwin in legal trouble and created the possibility of prison time for an actor who has been a TV and movie mainstay for nearly 40 years, with roles in the early blockbuster 'The Hunt for Red October,' Martin Scorsese's 'The Departed' and the sitcom '30 Rock.'

The indictment provides prosecutors with two alternative standards for pursuing an involuntary manslaughter charge against Baldwin in the death of Hutchins. One would be based on negligent use of a firearm, and the other alleges felony misconduct "with the total disregard or indifference for the safety of others."

Judges recently agreed to put on hold several civil lawsuits seeking compensation from Baldwin and producers of 'Rust' after prosecutors said they would present their case to a grand jury. Plaintiffs in those suits include members of the film crew.

Los Angeles-based attorney Gloria Allred, who is representing the slain cinematographer's parents and younger sister in a civil case, said Friday that her clients have been seeking the truth about what happened the day Hutchins was killed and will be looking forward to Baldwin's trial.



Neama Rahmani, a former federal prosecutor and president of the West Coast Trial Lawyers firm in Los Angeles, pointed to previous missteps by prosecutors, saying they will need to do more than present ballistics evidence to make a case that Baldwin had a broader responsibility and legal duty when it came to handling the gun on the set.

Special prosecutors dismissed an involuntary manslaughter charge against Baldwin in April, saying they were informed the gun might have been modified before the shooting and malfunctioned. They later pivoted and began weighing whether to refile a charge against Baldwin after receiving a new analysis of the gun.

The analysis from experts in ballistics and forensic testing relied on replacement parts to reassemble the gun fired by Baldwin, after parts of the pistol were broken during testing by the FBI. The report examined the gun and markings it left on a spent cartridge to conclude that the trigger had to have been pulled or depressed.

The analysis led by Lucien Haag of Forensic Science Services in Arizona stated that although Baldwin repeatedly denied pulling the trigger, "given the tests, findings and observations reported here, the trigger had to be pulled or depressed sufficiently to release the fully cocked or retracted hammer of the evidence revolver."

The weapons supervisor on the movie set, Hannah Gutierrez-Reed, has pleaded not guilty to involuntary manslaughter and evidence tampering in the case. Her trial is scheduled to begin in February.

'Rust' assistant director and safety coordinator David Halls pleaded no contest to unsafe handling of a firearm last March and received a suspended sentence of six months of probation. He agreed to cooperate in the investigation of the shooting.

An earlier FBI report on the agency's analysis of the gun found that, as is common with firearms of that design, it could go off without pulling the trigger if force was applied to an uncocked hammer, such as by dropping the weapon.

The only way the testers could get it to fire was by striking the gun with a mallet while the hammer was down and resting on the cartridge, or by pulling the trigger while it was fully cocked. The gun eventually broke during testing.

The 2021 shooting resulted in a series of civil lawsuits, including wrongful death claims filed by members of Hutchins' family, centred on accusations that the defendants were lax with safety standards. Baldwin and other defendants have disputed those allegations.

The Rust Movie Productions company has paid a $100,000 fine to state workplace safety regulators after a scathing narrative of failures in violation of standard industry protocols, including testimony that production managers took limited or no action to address two misfires on set before the fatal shooting.

The filming of 'Rust' resumed last year in Montana, under an agreement with the cinematographer's widower, Matthew Hutchins, that made him an executive producer.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Mental static could be causing you to struggle today. Whether you forgot your headphones at home, you keep being hounded by someone, or you solely have too many thoughts buzzing around in your brain.

TAURUS: The way that you feel right now may guide you toward giving up on a dream. While this is difficult to come to grips with, sometimes being discouraged by past struggles makes it seem easier to release what you once wanted.

GEMINI: You run the risk of being self-centred in a group today. But remember, nothing gives you the right to boss other people around or act in a way that only centres your opinion when you're working on a team.

CANCER: Your emotions can keep you in the dark. It may be that your present mindset has leaned negative, possibly due to a recent disappointment, or you might have just woken up on the wrong side of the bed.

LEO: Today, there could be a group of people around you that disagree with your routine or habits and aren't shy about letting you know. No matter how well-meaning they are, you don't have to let them pick at you at this time.

VIRGO: You're letting go of being stuck. Up until now, you may have let yourself hang onto negative habits that could be stunting your emotional growth or preventing you from releasing negative memories.

LIBRA: Your emotions might enable you to run away from problems. It can be difficult to stay and work things out when your emotions are telling you to run, and it could take a lot of mental willpower to overcome your recent impulses.

SCORPIO: You may be suspicious of your support system at this time. While this may be warranted, it's more likely that you're feeling this way because of negative past experiences that have left you overly guarded.

SAGITTARIUS: You may have to be someone else's rock. This can be a very emotionally chaotic time, and people could lash out at you emotionally, but this is usually due to their internal struggles.

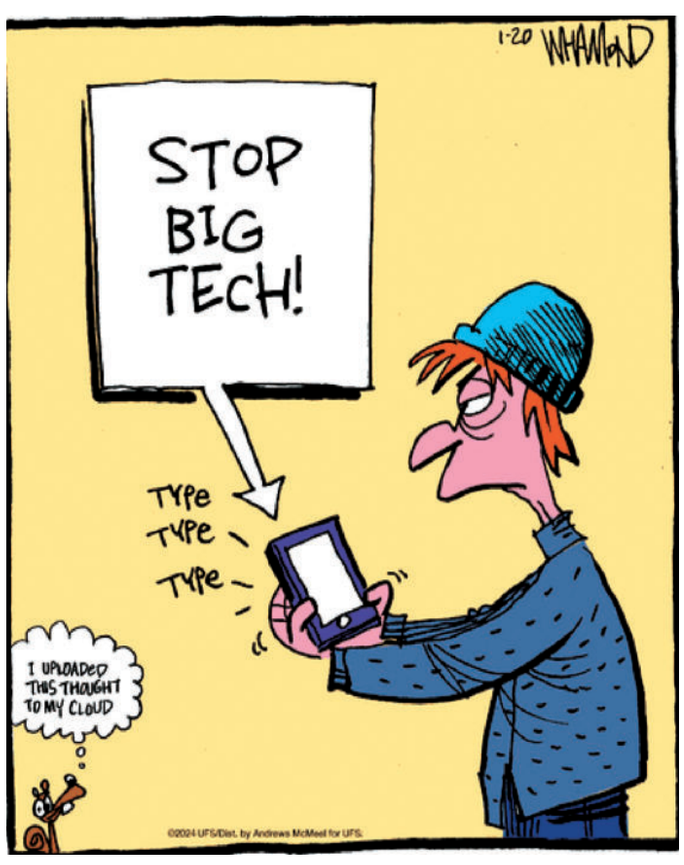
CAPRICORN: Bad habits can creep back in at any moment. It may be that you've overcome a difficult pattern, but stressors overwhelming you and temptations popping up could cause you to break your positive streak.

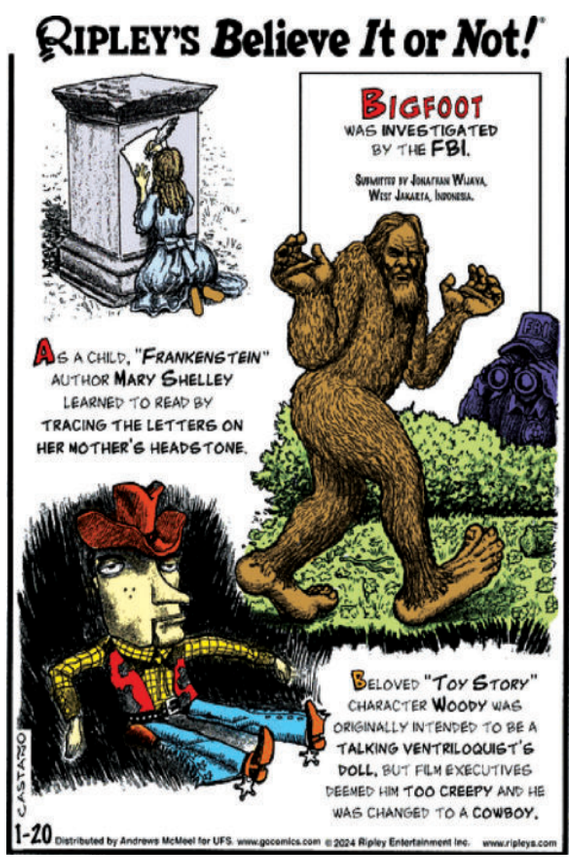
AQUARIUS: The impulse to express yourself may overwhelm you. While you could have a lot that you want to say, such as a crusade on social media or a statement to someone specific.

PISCES: Someone may be acting in a way that's against your moral code. While you can't really impose your own code on others, you could feel drawn to protect someone else.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Madhes registers third win beating Karnali by 61 runs



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Madhes Province registered its third win of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament defeating Karnali Provine by 61 runs at the TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday.

Madhes, which has played five matches in the tournament so far, climbed to the third position in the table after the win.

Winning the toss, Madhes elected to bat first. The opening pair of Harishankar Shah and Anil Sah gave Madhes a proper start. Madhes' first wicket fell in the form of Anil in the 14th over leaving the team at 85. Anil fell six runs short of his half-century.

Harishankar, on the other hand, was able to reach the 50-run mark but failed to go forward. Mayan Yadav, who entered the crease after the first wicket, was able to celebrate his 50; he too failed to score more after it.

The first four wickets of Madhes fell in the bag of Dipendra Rawat. Rawat completed his spell of 10 overs early as he was sending Madhes' top order back to the pavilion single-handedly.

Harishankar, Anil, Pawan Sarraf and Niraj Yadav were the victims of Rawat. Sarraf, who has been dangerous in the previous matches, could only score 11 runs while Niraj went for a duck after facing six balls. Abhishek Tiwari also added 34 runs for Madhes while batting at number 8.

Anuj Chanara took two wickets, including that of Tiwari, while Dinesh Adhikari, Unish Singh and Diwan Pun claimed one each for Karnali. Karnali bowlers only gave six runs as extras in the 50 overs where Madhes put on a total of 231 runs.

Nevertheless, Karnali failed to chase the target as Madhes' pacers suppressed the batsmen with swinging deliveries. Karnali's captain and opener Himanshu Shahi was caught in the slip in the bowl of Rajesh Yadav. Rajesh also took the wicket of Himanshu Shahi and sent him back after scoring only two runs in eight balls.

It was Bipin Shahi, another opener, who was only able to get to the boundary rope time and again for Karnali before Arjun Gharti, Karnali's wicket-keeper-batsman, joined him.

Bipin almost retired hurt as he suffered a strain on his leg while facing a ball in the early overs of the team's batting inning. He stood up after being treated by the physio and hit a total of six fours before departing at 31 runs off 38 balls.

Gharti was the only half-centurian for Karnali with two fours and two sixes. He departed after getting caught by Sarraf at 58 runs off 105 balls.

Bowler Dinesh Adhikari, who came after the fall of the eighth wicket, was the second-highest scorer for Karnali scoring 33 runs off 33 balls with three sixes and two fours. Diwan Pun was the final wicket of Karnali as the team got bundled at 170 runs in 41.1 overs.

All seven bowlers used by Madhes took at least one wicket in the match. Rajesh Yadav took three, Pradip Paswan bagged two, and Rupesh Singh, Abhishek Tiwari, Ranjit Kumar, Harishankar and Pawan claimed one each.

The tournament will give a break to TU Cricket Ground on Sunday as Gandaki and Koshi face each other at Mulpani International Cricket Ground. Bhairahawa Cricket Ground will see a departmental derby as Nepal Police Club faces Tribhuwan Army Club on Day 9.

PHOTO: CAN
Harishankar Shah, captain of Madhesh Province, celebrates after reaching the fifty milestone against Karnali Province on Day 8 of PM Cup.

Griezmann challenging Bellingham for most decisive player in Spain

AP
Barcelona, Jan. 20

After scoring a gorgeous winner to eliminate Real Madrid from the Copa del Rey, Antoine Griezmann once again eclipsed Jude Bellingham in their duel to be considered the most decisive player in Spain.

Griezmann beat Vinícius Júnior to the ball, danced down the end-line and curled a shot into the only spot he could – at a slim angle, just over the shoulder of goalkeeper Andriy Lunin. That third goal in added time put Atletico ahead for good in its 4-2 win over Madrid in the Copa del Rey on Thursday.

"Our substitutes gave us a boost and then the magic player that Griezmann is did his thing," Atletico coach Diego Simeone said about the keys to victory that put his side into the quarterfinals.

Madrid's only two losses in 29 games across all competitions this campaign, including the Champions League, have both come at the hands of Atletico.

Griezmann also notched the winner when Atletico beat Madrid 3-1 in the Spanish league in September. He likewise scored for Atletico in a 5-3 added-time loss to Madrid last week in the semifinals of the Spanish Super Cup played in Saudi Arabia.

Win or lose to Atletico's fiercest rival, Griezmann gave his all for his side by also acting as its best playmaker and helping his midfield in defence – a requisite for any player who wants to stay in Simeone's good graces.

And this for a player who Barcelona sent back to Atletico following two frustrating seasons after never being able to exploit his talents that helped France win the 2018 World Cup.

Since Griezmann's return to Atletico in Sept. 2021, it is like he never left. The 32-year-old Griezmann etched his name into the lore of Atletico by becoming its all-time leading scorer in Riyadh. The club honoured that achievement Thursday with a dedicatory playing shirt with the number 174 goals that broke Luis Aragonés's previous record. Griezmann then made it 175 goals in the victory.



PHOTO: MANU FERNANDEZ VIA AP
Antoine Griezmann, foreground, duels for the ball with Real Madrid's Eduardo Camavinga during a match of Copa del Rey in Madrid, Spain, Jan. 18, 2024.

"We have been fortunate to beat Madrid twice, and it is true that we are very strong at home," Griezmann said. "I am very happy with the effort of the entire team. We are tired and don't have much time to rest (before a league game at Granada on Monday), but we are thrilled."

While Griezmann continued to thrive against Madrid, Atletico proved again to be one of the very few teams that could keep Bellingham from completely running wild. Bellingham hit the woodwork early in Thursday's game and set up Joselu Mato to make it 2-2, but he was denied a goal.

Bellingham has quickly emerged as a world-class star after joining Madrid from Borussia Dortmund last summer. The 20-year-old has scored 17 goals, including a league-high 13 that have proven key to putting Madrid near the top of the table at just one point behind surprise leader Girona.

Griezmann has just bettered that tally with 18 goals overall. Atletico, however, has had some tough losses in the league in recent rounds and finds itself in fifth place at a full 10 points adrift Madrid. Madrid will have a chance to avenge the cup defeat on Feb. 4 when Atletico visits the Santiago Bernabeu in the league.

"Atlético, like us, made a tremendous effort. Nobody deserved to lose. We lost, but we have to look forward," Madrid coach Carlo Ancelotti said. "Now we have two weeks to work well and improve our fitness."

SNIPPETS

Inter to face Napoli for Italian Super Cup

Riyadh (AP): Inter Milan is hoping a midseason trophy will catapult the team to the Serie A title. The Nerazzurri are on track following a 3-0 win over Lazio in the Italian Super Cup semifinals on Friday. Serie A leader Inter will face Serie A titleholder Napoli in Monday's final (12:45 am on Tuesday in Nepali time). Napoli, lying eighth in the league, beat Fiorentina 3-0 on Thursday. Marcus Thuram put Inter ahead 17 minutes in at Al-Awwal Park Stadium after Federico Dimarco used a backheel flick to set up the France forward. Then Hakan Calhanoglu converted a penalty kick after the break and Davide Frattesi finished off a counterattack three minutes from time. The Italian Super Cup was always contested between the Serie A champion and the Italian Cup winner from the previous season but the format was changed this year to include the runners-up from those competitions.

Ashraf quits as interim head of Pakistan cricket

Islamabad (AP): Zaka Ashraf quit as the interim head of the Pakistan Cricket Board on Friday just days after the government stopped him from convening a meeting. The government's inter-provincial coordination committee asked Ashraf to cancel a PCB management committee meeting in Karachi this week and stopped him from taking any major financial decisions. However, Ashraf convened an urgent meeting of the 10-member management committee in Lahore on Friday and announced he had quit. Ashraf replaced Najam Sethi in July as chairman of the management committee. The government gave Ashraf until Feb. 4 to form a board of governors and organise an election of a PCB chairman but he failed. The Pakistan men's team endured below-par performances during Ashraf's tenure.

Salah set to miss 2 games with strained leg muscle

Abidjan (AP): Mohamed Salah will miss Egypt's next two games at the Africa Cup of Nations due to a left leg muscle strain. X-rays confirmed the extent of the injury that forced Salah off early during a 2-2 draw with Ghana on Thursday, the Egyptian Football Association said on Friday. Salah went off injured toward the end of the first half after sitting on the field and holding the back of his left thigh. "He will miss the team's next two matches in the African Nations against Cape Verde, and then the round of 16 match in the event of qualification," the EFA said on X. Egypt has yet to win a game at the Africa Cup. The Pharaohs are second to group winner Cape Verde. Only the top two in each group are assured of advancing. Egypt plays Cape Verde on Monday.

A 'miraculous' play could only stop Djokovic: Laver

AFP
Melbourne, Jan. 20

Laver, the only player to twice win all four singles Grand Slams in the same calendar year, called the Serbian superstar "amazing" and admitted he would be shocked if anyone beat him.

"He has all the shots, he knows exactly when he can play them, when he can't play them," the 85-year-old told Australian media after arriving at the tournament from his California home.

"He's priming himself to get through to the final."

Laver, who has the centre court at the Australian Open named after him, added that Djokovic's athletic prowess and tennis brain set him apart from everyone else.

"It almost unfolds in front of him, what he should be doing. He's a great champion," said the Australian 11-time Grand Slam winner.

"He serves well. His ground strokes are unbeatable. "I have to believe unless someone miraculously plays their best tennis to knock him off, they can start putting part of his initials on the trophy now."

Should Djokovic do as Laver expects, he will win a 25th Grand Slam to surpass Margaret Court's all-time record.



The 36-year-old dropped sets in his opening two matches at Melbourne Park when he said he was under the weather.

But he was back on form to coast into a fourth-round meeting with French 20th seed Adrian Mannarino.

DIWAKAR 'DAN' MAHARJAN PROMOTED TO 'S CLASS' REFEREE IN TAEKWONDO

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 20

Diwakar 'Dan' Maharjan has been promoted to 'S Class', the top position for an international referee in taekwondo, by World Taekwondo. It is the highest recognition by the South Korea-based World Taekwondo's headquarters to any international referee. Maharjan is Nepal's national taekwondo referee from 1988. He then started as a taekwondo trainer in the USA in 1995. He started his international refereeing career in Canada in 1999. He also owns US World Class Taekwondo Hollywood School in Portland, USA.

'S Class' means special category and is above the 1st class. An international referee needs to be continuously active in the sector for at least a decade and take part in at least 15 refresher courses. "I have been active in the taekwondo sector for decades and I believe the current recognition is a result of my hard work," Maharjan shared.

Maharjan also earned 8th Dan in two categories and became the first Nepali to do so. He earned two 8th-degree black belts from the Taekwondo Headquarters and the International Korean Martial Arts Federation.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:35 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.0	2.6	0.0
Dipayal	21.5	4.5	0.0
Dhangadi	16.2	9.0	0.0
Birendranagar	21.1	4.4	0.0
Nepalgunj	12.7	9.0	0.0
Jumla	12.0	-5.9	0.0
Ghorahi	19.9	5.6	0.0
Pokhara	20.0	7.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	12.5	6.6	0.0
Simara	12.6	9.2	0.0
Kathmandu	17.6	4.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.7	5.3	0.0
Taplejung	14.7	3.4	0.0
Dhankuta	20.8	6.7	0.0
Biratnagar	16.7	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	8.1	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	21.4	9.5	0.0*
Lumle	14.1	3.5	0.0*
Janakpur	16.2	9.5	0.0*
Jiri	13.0	-0.4	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 21, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.61	Rs. 133.21
Euro	1	Rs. 144.40	Rs. 145.05
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.22	Rs. 168.98
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.63	Rs. 153.32
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.46	Rs. 87.85
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.43	Rs. 98.87
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.92	Rs. 99.37
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.96	Rs. 9.00
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.38	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.74	Rs. 3.76
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.11	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.11	Rs. 28.24
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.69	Rs. 12.75
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.36	Rs. 19.45
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.80	Rs. 432.75
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.82	Rs. 353.41

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Low-key debut for Suarez as Miami held by El Salvador

AFP
San Salvador, Jan. 20

Suarez, who signed for Major League Soccer's Miami last month from Brazilian club Gremio, started in attack alongside Argentine superstar Messi at the Estadio Cuscatlan in San Salvador.

But the 36-year-old Uruguayan forward struggled to find his footing in a low-key start to his career with the Florida franchise.

Suarez, Messi and fellow former Barcelona players Sergio Busquets and Jordi Alba were all substituted at half-time with the match scoreless.

Messi came closest to opening the scoring on 36 minutes, latching on to a clever touch from Busquets and rifling a volley towards goal only to be denied by El Salvador goalkeeper Mario Martinez, who also stopped the Argentine's follow-up effort.

Martinez was also alert four minutes later when Alba burst into the box only to see his shot parried away.

El Salvador almost snatched victory in the 83rd minute, but Styven Vasquez's clever header cannoned off the bar.



Friday's match launched a hectic series of pre-season friendlies for Miami as they prepare to kick off the new MLS season against Real Salt Lake on February 21.

Miami plays FC Dallas in a friendly on Monday, then head to Saudi Arabia for games against Al-Hilal on January 29.

They face Al-Nassr on February 1 – a game that should see Messi line up against old rival Cristiano Ronaldo once more.

Miami then travels to Asia to play friendlies against a Hong Kong select team on February 4 before taking on Japanese side Vissel Kobe three days later.

The Herons return to the United States for a final pre-season game against Argentine squad Newell's Old Boys on February 15.

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